practices undertaken by this entity. It definitely does not mean engaging in military combat with an adversary. What it implies, simply, is dealing with a political faction without necessarily aiming at containing its rise, or even if so, then not doing that militarily or by using selective (or partisan) engagement tactics. India's debate on whether or not to engage with the Taliban, from this perspective, was that of opening a political channel with the hope of securing its interests in Taliban dominated territories, but without giving the militant group diplomatic recognition.

The idea of anti-engagement, on the other hand, implies partisan political support to one group over the other. Within the framework of such partisan support, use of coercive (military) means to communicate political intent is acceptable. The term also implies cutting diplomatic contact with the perceived adversary. However, what anti-engagement does not mean is an absence of contact with the country in question. Given the geographical proximity of Afghanistan and India, this has never been a viable strategic option for New Delhi. Even during the Taliban years, India chose to be deeply engaged with the anti-Taliban United Front (UF) rather than steering clear of the Afghan quagmire altogether. Also, anti-engagement, as seen vis-à-vis the Taliban, has not been India's traditional foreign policy approach. Even in Myanmar, a country where India officially supported the National League for Democracy, the pro-democracy political party led by Aung San Suu Kyi, New Delhi was engaging with the military *junta*. There are two reasons why the term anti-engagement is emphasised instead of 'containment'. Firstly, specific to this case, India did not have the means to effectively contain any political and military force in Afghanistan on its own. Even great powers like the imperial Britain, the Soviet Union, and the US-led NATO coalition forces, have contained Afghan militias with mixed results at best. Secondly, the most India has done to stop any group's rise to power in Afghanistan is to support its adversaries. During the 1990s civil war this was most visible. Thus, partisans may have a containment axiom to their political intent, but limited capability to carry it out militarily.

Note on sources